southwestern provinces, Yunnan and Sichuan, for operations against India, the American report suggested.

But it was never China's intention to conquer and keep territory. That was not part of the plan when the Chinese leadership decided to attack India. Geopolitically, China had made an important point, and that was sufficient. Nehru, in the 1950s a proponent of non-alignment, was humiliated and was no longer a leading voice among the then newly independent nations in Asia and Africa, as he had been since the historic conference in Bandung, Indonesia, in 1955. After the 1962 War, it was China rather than India, that became the leader of the Third World—an entirely new concept that China's omnipotent Chairman Mao Zedong had introduced to replace the old idea of non-alignment. The leader of the Third World would, of course, be Mao's China.

The timing of the decision by the Chinese leadership to 'settle accounts' with the Indians, to quote Deng, and to make use of all their preparations for war, must also be understood in the context of internal problems in China at the time. In 1958, Mao had initiated the disastrous Great Leap Forward to modernize China. By 1961, anywhere between 17 and 45 million people had died as a result of Mao's policies, which had caused a famine rather than, as intended, any rapid industrialization.

Mao was discredited and, very likely, on his way out. He must have felt he had to regain power—and that the best way to do that would be to unify the nation and especially the armed forces against an outside enemy. India was a 'soft' target because it had, in 1959, granted the Dalai Lama asylum after he had fled there in the wake of the failed uprising against the Chinese occupation of Tibet. The Tibetan god-king had been allowed to set up a government in exile in McLeodganj in northern India. And then there was the issue of a border that China did not recognize.

MacFarquhar writes in his comprehensive history of the origins of China's Cultural Revolution that there is always a close relationship between China's domestic and foreign policy. In Mao's worldview, the Chinese revolution was part of a global series of events, with interaction both ways. However, MacFarquhar states that the connection between Chinese military actions and domestic politics is more obscure. According to him, 'China's involvement in the Korean War, which broke out in 1950, enabled the Chinese Communist Party's leaders to launch a patriotic campaign to solidify the people behind them'.[27]